

Mitosis, meiosis or scrambled EGGs?

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The EGG Summer School in Generative Grammar is now in its fourth decade. I have taught at four EGGs—Debrecen (1998), Lublin (2004), Constanța (2010) and Zagreb (2025). At my first EGG in 1998, I was an Assistant Professor at Concordia in Montreal and a teacher at EGG for two courses related to my 1995 thesis on phonological theory, and I made many friends. One of these friends was finishing her PhD in Eastern Europe and teaching at her home institution. She was at EGG as a student, with her 7-year-old daughter in tow. We are now married, we work together, we wrote a linguistics textbook containing photos of our son, and we expect to be grandparents soon—maybe a first for EGG progeny.

Among the many other friends I made at that EGG is one with whom I co-edited a volume (I still feel guilty because she did all the work) and one who is the series editor for the textbook my wife and I wrote.

Over the years, I have recommended the EGG to many students. Out of the nine people currently teaching in my program, five have attended at least one EGG. One of my most vivid memories of the Constanța EGG is a conversation I had at a midnight beach party standing between two young women, a Canadian grad student who had done her undergrad at my university, with a beer in her hand, and an eighteen year-old Turkish student in a hijab. That moment captures the essence of EGG for me—people of different ages, cultures, and levels of education, being themselves, making friends and talking about distinctive features. That Canadian student is now a linguistics professor.

Another former Concordia student was in Constanța, attending EGG with the linguist boyfriend she had met in grad school. They now have a child, and they both work as linguists, one at Apple and one at Google. My teenaged Romanian niece and nephew also came from Bucharest to stay with me in Constanța for a few nights, and the EGG organizers helpfully got them a room of their own in the dorm, so that they didn't have to disturb their cranky middle-aged uncle when they came in late.

Aside from the EGG alums that are now my colleagues, there are others who have left the Concordia nest since hatching. One undergraduate man went to EGG and came back engaged to a woman ten years his senior. He went back to the EGG the following year, continued on to a PhD program and is

*This note represents only my own opinions and thoughts—not those of the EGG or OVA school organizers or anyone else.

now an industry linguist. Another one of the five Concordians who attended that year also did a PhD in Linguistics, and she is doing okay as a Professor of Experimental Philosophy.

One of the local organizers this year in Zagreb was my colleague in Montreal until recently. He and another teacher this year have been my co-authors separately on several papers each. There were also eight of my students, current or former, in attendance. I have to admit that it was nice to flock together with so many birds of a Concordia feather.

In short, the EGG represents for me some of the best, most wholesome things in life—intellectual stimulation, mentoring students, fun in the sun, companionship, and arguing vociferously with Tobias Scheer about linguistics and politics, then laughing and drinking a beer together.

So what? Many of you are aware of a schism in the EGG world. A group of people formerly associated with EGG in some capacity have set up OVA, another generative linguistics summer school in Eastern Europe, with a clever name that serves as a wonderful tribute to the original. In principle, this is fantastic news—you can never have too many high quality, affordable, summer schools in generative linguistics in places where beer is cheap, right? The only problem is that the OVA organizers, instead of offering students more options, have chosen to hold their school at exactly the period from the last week of July to the first week of August that the EGG has been using for over thirty years. This strikes me as gratuitously insensitive and inconsistent with the generosity of spirit and idealism which has always guided the actual EGG school, the institution from which OVA explicitly derives its inspiration. For a group advocating enhanced sensitivity and emotional safety, this counter-productive decision runs the risk of appearing careless at best, and mean-spirited at worst. I suggest that the OVA-ists correct this probably unintentional oversight and shift their dates to allow students, the group we all care about, to benefit from both schools.¹ Our summer schools should not be competing for enrollments in a zero-sum mindset in the manner of corporatized universities.

What led to this unfortunate situation that can only harm both programs? I will not summarize the long-winded accusations and counter-accusations from multiple sides that can be found online—in fact I have not read most of that stuff. Instead I will focus on a few issues that I think are worth considering based on my own EGGsperiences² and imperfect knowledge.

- Gossip from the last millenium. At my first EGG in 1998, there were whispers of an unrelated linguistics summer school from several years prior where the party atmosphere was really, really intense. The current unsubstantiated rumors about unbridled licentiousness at the EGG appear to me to derive from prurient gossip from thirty-five years ago! On the one hand, I don't think there has been any substantiation of rumors of

¹I am an optimistic old fool, so I hold out some hope that each planned 2026 school is a mere gamete and that fertilization could still occur.

²Please see <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f04ULfzkMhY> for an appreciation of the eggstent to which I have restrained myself. I grew up on this stuff.

comparable behavior at EGG, but on the other hand, the EGG organizers, as far as I know, would not be responsible for, nor interested in the existence of such putative events, as long as all private behavior was consensual. It is my understanding that EGG teachers and organizers do not think it appropriate to impose and police private morality. EGG school is not Liberty University, which Wikipedia tells us “prohibits premarital sex, cohabitation, any kind of romantic relationship between members of the same sex, and alcohol use.”

- Problematic behavior (stereotypically of the toxic masculinity type) is rare at EGG, and when it has occurred, the organizers have dealt with it efficiently and proportionally, as far as I am aware. For example, at one EGG I attended, a teacher was expelled from the dormitory for the remainder of the school for anti-social behavior. Problem solved.
- The EGG does and does not have a Code of Conduct. It does in the sense that the school reserves the right to expel individuals for behavior that violates the standards of human decency, but it does not aim to paternalistically circumscribe all the ways in which a group of adults should interact. Since EGG teachers and board members have no expertise in investigation, mediation, forensics, etc. it would be imprudent to adopt an unworkable and unenforceable detailed Code of Conduct. EGG assumes that people tend to know what is acceptable or unacceptable behavior and does not condescend to provide lists of obvious examples.
- The EGG assumes that spirited, animated and even volatile or cantankerous discussion of linguistics and other topics is an important part of interaction among intelligent, well-intentioned people. Part of an EGG education may include witnessing participants engaged in such passionate arguments heading off to drink a coffee together after class. EGG encourages intensity, integrity and a demand for precision over wishy-washiness as a means to intellectual progress. I maintain that it is even pedagogically useful for students to see me at my wits’ end, trying to dismiss a phonological argument from Tobias without resorting to an invalid *ad hominem* attack on his sartorial choices.
- One of the issues that led to the EGG schism is how to handle the balance of gender among the teachers. This is a legitimate issue of discussion from many angles. First is the question of whether the issue matters at all. I assume that it does. Second is whether the issue should be handled by a strict policy encoded in an organization’s rules or by more fluid common sense and an assumption of good will by all parties. Third is the issue of time-scale—does every single EGG school have to have a perfect gender balance of teachers? Fourth, does every single domain (Semantics, Syntax, Phonology) have to have a gender balance at each school? Fifth, what is to be done in the case of teachers who do not identify as cis-male or cis-female—what expertise does a bunch of nerd linguists on a summer school

board have in dealing with such issues? How does OVA plan to address this? Sixth, if accusations have been made concerning gender bias in teacher selection in the past, has the putative imbalance been shown to be intentional and statistically significant? Seventh, have other factors been ruled out—for example, does an imbalance in EGG representation correlate with an imbalance in the field as a whole, and what should be done if it does or does not? The complexity of all these issues suggests that good will and dialogue promise better outcomes than both walking away from the table and rigid codification.

- Diversity and safety. Concordia’s representation at EGG over the years covers a wide range of ages, ethnicities, levels of education, gender identities, sexual orientations, and so on. I sometimes worry about students travelling to EGG by train or bus, or out in a bar, in less tolerant regions of Eastern Europe. However, I am never concerned about how queer or trans or racialized students are treated in the EGG nest. From what I have seen and heard, the EGG has been welcoming and supportive to all kinds of people and allowed everyone to get to know each other in safety. This atmosphere reflects EGG’s history and reputation and the dedication of its *volunteer* organizers and teachers, year in and year out, over more than three decades.

The creation and maintenance of the EGG’s wholesome and exhilarating vibe is a credit to the time-tested expertise and devotion of those who have made massive donations of time and effort. Such people have stuck around, and they will stick around. This kind of institutional memory is the best guarantee of the EGG’s longevity, as well as for the safety and intellectual growth of students and teachers alike. I wish only success to the EGG, OVA, NYI, Creteling, Leiden Summer School in Languages and Linguistics and the all the rest. Let’s just hope that organizers of each school will abjure underhanded methods that divide, rather than unify theoretical linguists.